

What is justice?

This question breaks down into a number of sub-questions. We can ask what it means for a **person** to be just. We can also ask what it means for an **international system** of distinct societies to be just.

Today we are going to focus on the question of what it means for an individual society — which for our purposes we can take to be a nation — to be just.

This question is sometimes called the question of **distributive justice**, because it asks about the just distribution of goods within a society at a time.

What goods are we talking about?

One category is what we might call **material goods**. These include things like food and property and income.

But these are not the only goods. Other goods include **political rights** (such as the right to vote) and **liberties** (such as the freedom to choose where one lives or whom one marries or what job one pursues). As we will see, there are others.

Our question is: what makes some societies unjust? What is required for the distribution of goods in a society to be a just distribution? We'll look at four kinds of answer to this question.

an individual society → which for our purposes we can take to be a

mean for an international system of distinct societies to be just.

nation — to be just.

ask what it means for a person to be just. We can also ask what it

Today we are going to focus on the question of what it means for

This question breaks down into a number of sub-questions. We can

justice, because it asks about the just distribution of goods within

This question is sometimes called the question of distributive

a society at a time.

things like food and property and income.

One category is what we might call material goods. These include

But these are not the only goods. Other goods include political

freedom to choose where one lives or whom one marries or what job

one pursues). As we will see, there are others.

rights (such as the right to vote) and liberties (such as the

Our question is: what makes some societies unjust? What is

required for the distribution of goods in a society to be a just

distribution? We'll look at four kinds of answers to this question.

This is enough to describe a society which most of us would agree

to be unjust.



enslaved the members of group B, depriving them by force of their

political rights and liberties (such as freedom of association and the

At some initial time t , the members of a society are living in a state of

freedom to pursue an education). By time $t+2$, group A owns all the

relative quality. But at later time $t+1$, sub-group A takes all of

the property of subgroup B . Group A consolidates its power, and

property, and gives members of group B only the are minimized

in the ways that members of group A direct.

for survival. Members of group B are only permitted to serve group A

It is universal that, at $t+2$, this is an unjust society.